



Malachite

△ Piece of fibrous malachite

Malachite powder was used as eyeshadow, pigment for wall painting, and in glazes and coloured glass in ancient Egypt around 5,000 years ago. It was also a major source of copper, as it still is. The ancient Greeks used it in children's amulets, the Romans to ward off the evil eye, and the Chinese to decorate vases. In the 19th century, huge quantities were mined in the Ural Mountains, Russia, and an entire cathedral was decorated with it. Today, it is an important gemstone and ornamental mineral, used in cabochons, polished slabs, and carvings.

Specification

Chemical name Copper carbonate | **Formula** $\text{Cu}_2\text{CO}_3(\text{OH})_2$
Colours Bright green | **Structure** Monoclinic | **Hardness** 3.5–4 | **SG** 3.2–4.1 | **RI** 1.65–1.91 | **Lustre** Adamantine to silky | **Streak** Pale green | **Locations** DR Congo, Australia, Morocco, USA, France



Gem malachite | Rough | When sliced across the "bubbles", this malachite rough will produce fantastic "bulls-eye" patterns, as in this example.



Peruvian malachite | Rough | This example from the Atacama desert of Peru features malachite crystals that have developed on a bed of atacamite.



Stalactitic habit of malachite | Rough | It is reasonably common for malachite to occur in stalactitic form, sometimes giving rise to irregular shapes such as this.

... a field of
ripe cabbages
with their
prevailing
hue of
malachite
green...

Walt **Whitman**
Author



Spectacular patterns | Cut | When sliced across the "bubbly" structure of malachite, a stunning pattern is revealed, as shown in this polished slice.



Malachite pendant | Set | This polished piece of malachite is cut to show a cross section of its layers in a sweeping, linear arrangement, in contrast to the popular "bubble"-style patterns. It is set in an unusual pendant with silver and diamonds.



Diamond setting